CHAPTER SIX

What Precisely Is "Criticism of Israel"?

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Judith Butler opens *Parting Ways*, her critique of Zionism, by stating that one of her aims in writing this book was "to debunk the claim that any and all criticism of the State of Israel is effectively anti-Semitic."[1] On first encounter, the statement astonishes, for no serious person claims that "any and all criticism" of Israel is antisemitic. For those acquainted with contemporary anti-Zionist discourse, though, Butler's words are a familiar ploy and have been used countless times by others. They are meant to gain instant victim status for the speaker by claiming that anyone who dares to dissent from what is alleged to be "the party line" on Israel is sure to be denounced as an antisemite and, thereby, instantly silenced. Formulaic in character, Butler's words are a recognizable trope within a new political-rhetorical genre that calls itself "criticism of Israel." It does not typically resemble other modes of cultural or political criticism but has its own peculiar logic, identifiable vocabulary, narrative conventions, and predictable outcomes. By turns accusatory and derogatory, "criticism of Israel" feeds a discourse of demonization whose aim is the negation of Zionism and the delegitimization and, ultimately, the elimination of Israel as the nation state of the Jewish people. We shall expose this discourse for what it is: not an expression of normative criticism but a new and potent strain of rhetorical hostility focused on the Jewish state and its supporters. This negatively charged language is being employed at a time when assaults against Jews and Jewish institutions are annually numbering in the hundreds, and antisemitism once again is a serious threat, made all the worse by the rhetorical abuse that helps to fuel it.

Much of this rhetoric is directed aggressively against the Jewish state and those deemed "guilty" of backing it. Often hardly distinguishable from verbal antisemitism at its ugliest, it issues not only from jihadist preachers and neo-Nazi hate-mongers but increasingly from otherwise respectable intellectuals, scholars, artists, and journalists, some of whom are themselves Jews. These writers were the subject of my December 2006 essay, "Progressive Jewish

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